

TIOBE Index March 2026: How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

A Data-Backed Analysis of Programming Language Popularity Trends

Source: TIOBE Programming Community Index (tiobe.com)

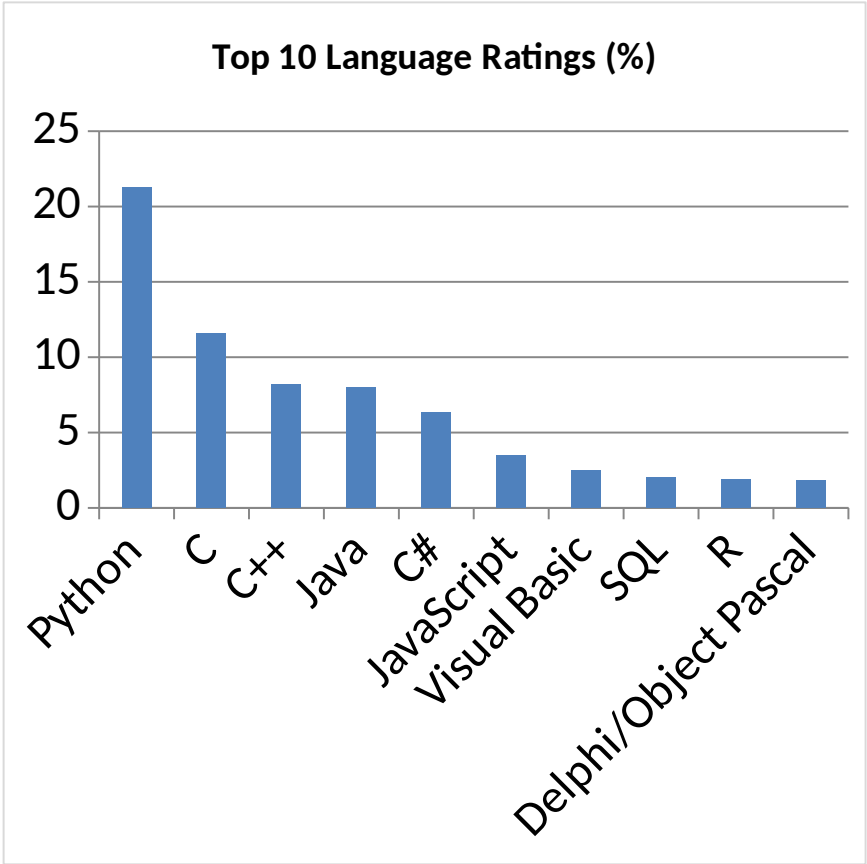
Methodology: Search-engine hit counts across Google, Bing, Wikipedia,
Amazon, and 20+ sites

Audience: Software Engineering Leads & Technology Strategists

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Top 20 Programming Languages — March 2026 vs. March 2025

Rank 2026	Rank 2025	Language	Rating	YoY Change
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%



Key Insight: The top 4 languages (Python, C, C++, Java) hold 48.97% of the total index. Python leads by 2× over C, yet posted the largest YoY decline (-2.59 pp) among the top 5.

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

Languages with the most dramatic rank changes year-over-year

▲ BIGGEST GAINERS

Perl — 24th → 11th (+1.05%)

Legacy data-processing & sysadmin revival

R — 16th → 9th (+0.94%)

Data science & statistical computing growth

Swift — 26th → 20th (+0.44%)

Apple platform ecosystem expansion

Assembly — 17th → 17th (+0.42%)

Embedded & low-level systems demand

C — 4th → 2nd (+2.02%)

Resurgence in systems & embedded programming

▼ BIGGEST LOSERS

Go — 7th → 16th (-1.49%)

Sharpest decline; possible Rust displacement

C++ — 2nd → 3rd (-2.90%)

Largest absolute rating drop in top 20

Java — 3rd → 4th (-2.37%)

Continued long-term erosion from peak

Python — 1st → 1st (-2.59%)

Largest top-5 decline; dominance under pressure

PHP — 13th → 18th (-0.25%)

Steady downward trend in web backend share

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Rank positions across four decades (1986–2026)

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996	1991	1986
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17	—	—
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2	2	9
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31	—	—
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	—	—	—
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33	—	—
Go	10	11	60	16	—	—	—	—	—
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6	10	3
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8	4	2

- Python's meteoric rise: From ~8th in 2006 to #1 after 2018, peaking above 25% before settling at 21.25% in March 2026.
- C's resilience: Held a top-2 position for most of the 24-year span, with periodic surges around 2015 and 2025–2026.
- Java's long decline: Dominated from ~2005 to 2018 (25%+), but has steadily fallen to under 8%.
- JavaScript's plateau: Despite web dominance, never exceeded ~5% on TIOBE and currently sits at 3.45%.
- Lisp fell from #2 (1986) to #26 (2026); Ada peaked at #3 (1986) and now sits at #14. C is the only language in the top 2 across all nine measurement points.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other

TIOBE Programming Language of the Year winners (2016–2025)

Python

6 total wins
2007, 2010, 2018,
2020, 2021, 2024

Most awarded language in TIOBE
history

Year	Winner
2025	C#
2024	Python
2023	C#
2022	C++
2021	Python
2020	Python
2019	C
2018	Python
2016	Go

C#

2 recent wins
2023, 2025

Reflects continued .NET ecosystem
growth

Note: The 2017 winner is not available in the source data. Go won in 2016, preceding its current decline from 7th to 16th. Python's 6 wins contrast with its recent -2.59 pp YoY drop, suggesting even dominant languages face cyclical pressure.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Actionable implications for technology decision-makers

1. Python dominance vs. decline trajectory

- At 21.25%, Python remains the safest bet for hiring and training pools.
- Yet its -2.59 pp YoY drop is the largest among the top 5 — monitor for sustained erosion.

2. C's resurgence signals systems-programming demand

- C climbed from 4th to 2nd (+2.02 pp). Embedded, IoT, and low-level tooling investments are warranted.

3. Legacy-language revival (Perl, R, Fortran)

- Perl jumped 13 spots; R climbed 7. Scientific computing and data-analysis stacks remain relevant.

4. Go's sharp fall demands caution

- Dropping from 7th to 16th (-1.49 pp) suggests displacement by Rust (+0.09%) in systems programming.
- Re-evaluate greenfield Go investments against Rust's trajectory.

5. Concentration risk in the top 4

- Python + C + C++ + Java = 48.97% of the index. Betting on only these four creates monoculture risk.
- Diversify training and tooling budgets to capture emerging momentum (Swift, Rust, R).

6. Swift re-enters top 20; Kotlin exits

- Apple-platform growth favors Swift. Cross-platform frameworks may be pressuring Kotlin.

Bottom line: Align hiring, training, and tooling investments with languages that show sustained upward momentum — not just historical dominance.